Not so Ashoka, whose persona can be seen in chronicles written some four centuries after his death. These show us how a variety of texts chose to understand Ashoka's life and times; but the details within such accounts have to be looked at with a sceptical eye, in part because they may have been purposive, or shaped by the ideological predispositions of commissioning patrons; in part because they are frequently coloured by the individual preconceptions and assumptions of their authors; and in part because when reading them it often becomes difficult to separate the historical Ashoka from the idealized literary portrait of a Buddhist monarch. An element of discrimination can be introduced by using archaeology to assess the reliability of parts of the legends and literature surrounding the Mauryan emperor. But, on the whole, given the limitations, it is clearly not possible to write up Ashoka's life in a way that meets modern biographical criteria. Fortunately, Ashoka does not have to be written about only in this way. We can understand his kingship and his personality, his empire and its neighbours, because he himself, fairly early in his kingly career, chose to speak.

The communicator *par excellence* of ancient India, Ashoka spent a great deal of time thinking through and having messages about his conception of morality engraved on stone for public consumption. Other Asian rulers also communicated through inscriptions, notably the Achaemenid kings of Iran (550–330 BCE). However, unlike Ashoka's, their public inscriptions devote much space and superlatives to how foes were killed off and conquered.[9]

There is, of course, great communicative diversity in different societies and time periods, and kingly epigraphs carved on stone represent one method. Naturally, however, much of the communication in the first millennium BCE was really not through writing but through talk and speech. Rhetoric in ancient Greece, with its emphasis on logical argument, reasoned debate, and emotive persuasion was in this mode. Such communication between rulers and the ruled was far more direct and audience-centred than